Transforming Customer Experiences: A UX Design Case Study for Foodie Explorer

Jessica A. Miller

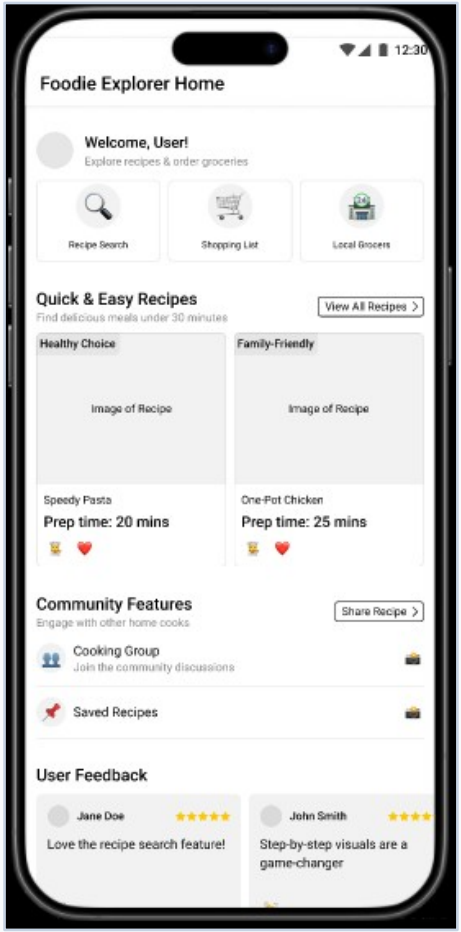
Project overview

The product:

A mobile app called “Foodie Explorer”

Project duration:

3-6 months



Project overview

The problem:
David is a freelance photographer who needs a reliable and efficient way to look up recipes and order groceries online.

The goal:
Our Foodie Explorer app enables users to search for recipes and order groceries for delivery. It is designed for busy professionals who want to cook healthy meals, support local businesses, and avoid the costs associated with pre-packaged meal subscriptions. We will evaluate the app's effectiveness through surveys offered within the platform.

Project overview

My role:

Lead UX Designer and Researcher

Responsibilities:

- Conducted user research (surveys, usability studies).
- Synthesized research to identify pain points and user needs.
- Redesigned the app with enhanced search, personalized suggestions, and simplified navigation.
- Developed wireframes and a low-fidelity prototype.
- Incorporated accessibility and user-informed design improvements (e.g., streamlined checkout, intuitive search).

01

Understanding the user

- User research
- Personas
- Problem statements
- User journey maps

User research: summary



For the Foodie Explorer UX case study, I performed user research by utilizing surveys and usability tests to grasp the needs of busy professionals seeking a more effective way to find recipes and purchase groceries.

At first, I thought that the main priority for users was convenience, but the research showed that they also appreciated features such as meal planning, step-by-step visual instructions, and the ability to support local businesses.

These findings led to a redesign of the app, focusing on an easy-to-use search capability, personalized suggestions, and simplified navigation to improve the overall user experience.

User research: pain points

1

Time Constraints

Users struggle to find time for grocery shopping and meal planning due to their busy schedules.

2

Inconsistent Quality

Frustration with previous grocery delivery services due to inconsistent product freshness and availability.

3

Complex Navigation

Users found some grocery and recipe apps difficult to navigate, making the process feel overwhelming.

4

Lack of Personalization

Many apps do not offer tailored recipe recommendations based on dietary needs and ingredient availability, leading to wasted time searching for suitable options.

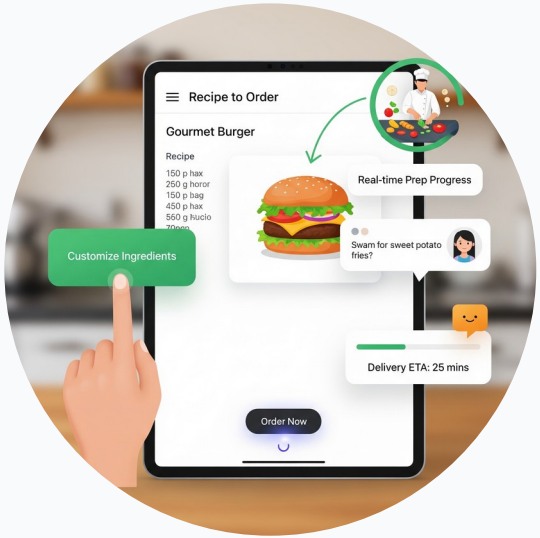
Key Learnings and Impact

01 User-centered design is crucial for effective solutions.

02 Streamlining the recipe-to-order process saves significant time.

03 Small usability changes greatly enhance the user experience.

04 Iterative design based on real user feedback is essential.



Persona: **David Miller**

Problem statement:

David Miller is a 42-year-old busy professional who needs a reliable and efficient way to look up recipes and order groceries online.

Persona based on user research for this case study.



Name: David Miller

Age: 42

Hometown: Portland, Oregon (a city known for its vibrant arts and food scene)

Education: Bachelor of Fine Arts in Photography from the University of Oregon

Family: Married to Sarah, two children (ages 8 and 10)

Occupation: Freelance Photographer specializing in portrait and event photography

David rushes home from a wedding shoot, exhausted, dreaming of a quick meal instead of the grocery store. Family dinner night looms, filling him with dread. A romantic date night is planned, but he lacks the time and inspiration to cook. He yearns for a solution that saves time, allows him to explore new cuisines, and simplifies his hectic life.

"Life's too short for boring meals and grocery store lines. I need a solution that's as creative as my photography."

Goals:

- **Save Time:** Reclaim precious hours spent on grocery shopping and errands.
- **Enjoy Family Time:** Spend more quality time with his wife and children.
- **Explore New Foods:** Discover new and exciting culinary experiences.
- **Support Local Businesses:** Find and support local restaurants and food producers.
- **Simplify Life:** Streamline his weekly routine and reduce stress.

Frustrations:

- **Time Constraints:** Juggling photography shoots, family commitments, and household chores leaves little time for grocery shopping.
- **Grocery Store Hassle:** Dislikes the crowds, long lines, and time-consuming nature of in-store shopping.
- **Limited Time for Cooking:** Busy schedule often leaves him with little time to cook elaborate meals.
- **Finding Quality Ingredients:** Difficulty finding fresh, local, and high-quality produce and other groceries.
- **Inconsistent Quality:** Frustrated with inconsistent quality from previous grocery delivery services.

User journey map

David's journey highlights his desire for a seamless grocery shopping experience. He seeks a solution that saves time, offers convenient ordering, and ensures access to high-quality products. By creating an app tailored to his needs, businesses can cultivate brand loyalty, foster word-of-mouth referrals, and gain valuable insights into customer preferences.

Action	Learn about the service and its benefits	Gather information and compare options	Make a purchase and complete the transaction	Receive the order as expected and ensure quality	Share experiences and build trust with the company
Task List	See ad, hear from friend website browse	Research features compare prices Read reviews	Place order select payment confirm order	Track delivery receive order unpack order	Rate the experience share on social media reorder
Feeling Adjective	Curious Intrigued	Hesitant, Uncertain	Excited Anxious	Impatient Excited Delighted	Satisfied Generous Loyal
Improvement Opportunities	More targeted ads, referral program, eye-catching visuals	Easier navigation, high-quality photos, clear filtering options	Faster checkout, multiple payment options, order confirmation email	Estimated delivery window, order tracking updates, easy-to-reach customer support	Incentivize reviews, shareable social media posts, loyalty program

Foodie Explorer: Features & Benefits

- Smart Recipe Discovery: Search for recipes based on the ingredients you already have, your dietary needs, preferred cuisine, or cooking time. No more wasted food or endless scrolling, just instant options that fit your lifestyle.
- Quick & Easy Recipes: Enjoy weeknight meals that can be prepared in 30 minutes or less. Ideal for busy individuals who still desire delicious, home-cooked food.
- Step-by-Step Visual Guides: Each recipe includes clear instructions and visuals, making cooking approachable for everyone, even beginners. With no guesswork involved, you'll achieve great results.
- Integrated Grocery Lists: Automatically create shopping lists from your chosen recipes to simplify grocery trips and save you time.
- Meal Planning Tools: Organize your meals for the week to avoid last-minute stress and maintain healthy eating habits.
- Features: Save your favorite recipes, share your culinary creations, and find inspiration within a community of fellow home cooks.

Foodie Explorer: Features & Benefits

Foodie Explorer simplifies every step of meal prep, from finding recipes to planning, shopping, and cooking. It's not just an app, it's a stress-reliever, a time-saver, and a way to bring joy back to home cooking. With Foodie Explorer, you'll save time, reduce waste, and feel empowered to eat better without the hassle.

Why It Matters to Our Users:

- *For busy schedules:* The quick recipes and grocery tools make life easier for professionals with little free time.
- *For inspiration:* Smart discovery and community sharing spark creativity and keep meals exciting.
- *For cooking confidence:* Visual instructions give even novice cooks the tools to succeed in the kitchen.
- *For healthier habits:* Meal planning and ingredient control lead to better eating for you and your family.

Connection: We designed Foodie Explorer for people who want great meals but don't have hours to spare. By combining smart discovery, intuitive tools, and a supportive community, we meet your needs at every stage, helping you reclaim time, reduce stress, and enjoy the satisfaction of home-cooked meals.

02

Starting the design

- Paper wireframes
- Digital wireframes
- Low-fidelity prototype
- Usability studies

Paper wireframes

Foodie Explorer app wireframe. It will have a clean, user-friendly layout that includes:

- Recipe Discovery section
- Quick & Easy Recipes for busy users
- Step-by-Step Visual Guides
- Integrated Grocery Lists
- Meal Planning Tools
- Community Features for user engagement

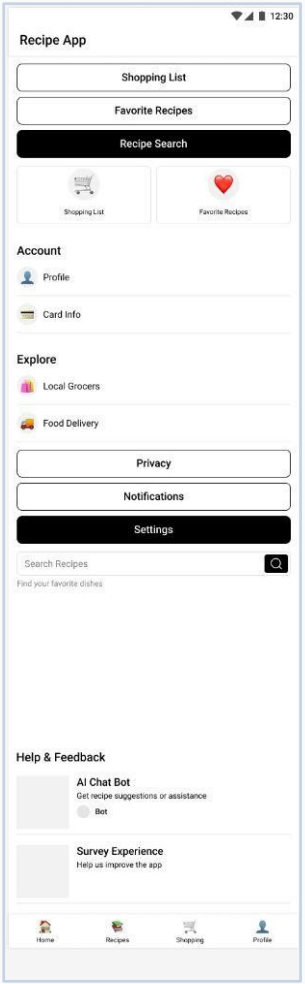


Digital wireframes

Wireframe Example Description:

1. Layout:
   - A prominent search bar at the top with placeholder text: *"Search recipes by ingredients, dietary needs, cuisine, or time."*
   - Below the search bar, a horizontal row of filter chips (e.g., *Vegetarian*, *Under 30 mins*, *Asian Cuisine*).
   - Cards display recipe previews with:
     - A thumbnail image of the dish.
     - Recipe title, estimated cooking time, and key tags (e.g., *Gluten-Free, Quick*).
2. Call-to-Actions (CTAs):
   - Search Button: Located beside the search bar for ease of use.
   - Save Recipe: A small heart icon overlay on recipe cards for quick saving.
3. Usability Enhancements:
   - Sticky navigation bar at the bottom for quick access to other app sections (e.g., *Home*, *Meal Planner*, *Community*).
   - Visual clarity with sufficient white space and a minimalist design.

Search Engine for User



Easy Navigation menu

Low-fidelity prototype

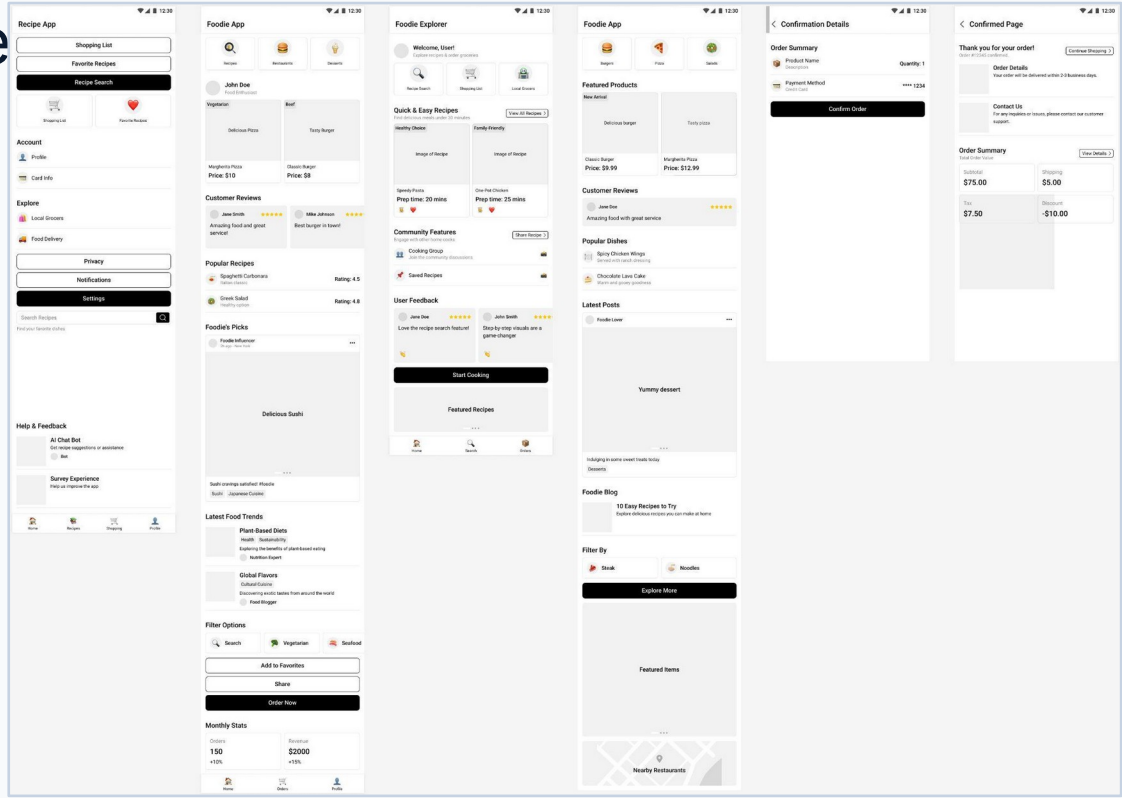
Goals & Thought Process:

Addresses"Time Constraints" by simplifying the path from recipe selection to grocery ordering. The goal was to eliminate manual list-making and simplify checkout for maximum efficiency.

Element & User Benefit:

Element: Integrated, auto-generated Grocery List and a streamlined, one-page Checkout flow.

Benefit: Users can add all recipe ingredients to a shopping list with one tap and complete the order quickly, saving significant time for busy professionals.



Usability study: findings

We conducted a usability study to evaluate Foodie Explorer's core features, like recipe search and grocery ordering. The study revealed that users valued an intuitive search bar and filters, as well as step-by-step visual guides for recipes. These findings informed key design improvements to enhance the user experience.

Round 1 findings

1. **Intuitive Search**: Users found the search bar and filters easy to use, significantly simplifying recipe discovery.
2. **Visual Guides**: Step-by-step visuals increased user confidence and engagement, especially for novice cooks.
3. **Streamlined Navigation**: Participants appreciated the minimalist design, which made navigation quick and straightforward.

Round 2 findings

1. Improved accessibility features, such as larger text and high-contrast mode, enhanced usability for a broader range of users.
2. Users appreciated the addition of personalized recommendations, which made the app feel more tailored to their needs.
3. Streamlined checkout flow reduced the time to complete grocery orders, improving overall satisfaction.

03

Refining the design

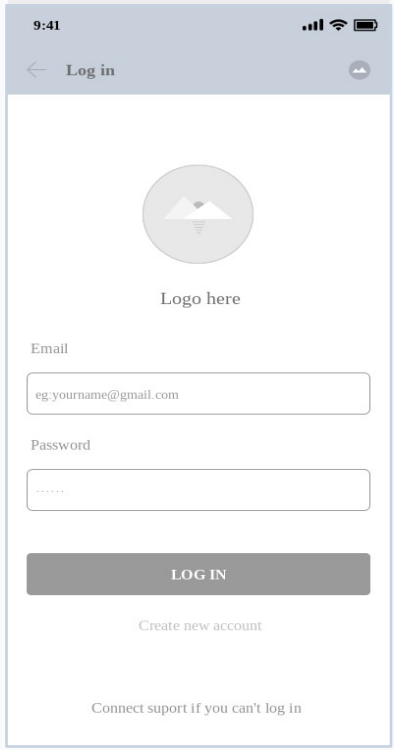
- Mockups
- High-fidelity prototype
- Accessibility

Mockups

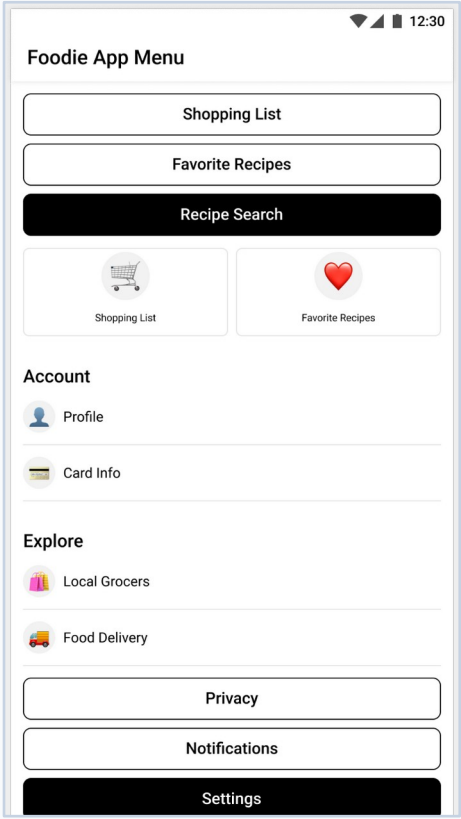
Before Usability Study: Initial designs featured a simple layout with basic navigation but lacked personalization and accessibility enhancements.

After Usability Study: Improved designs included better search filters, larger buttons, and personalized recommendations, making navigation smoother and more intuitive.

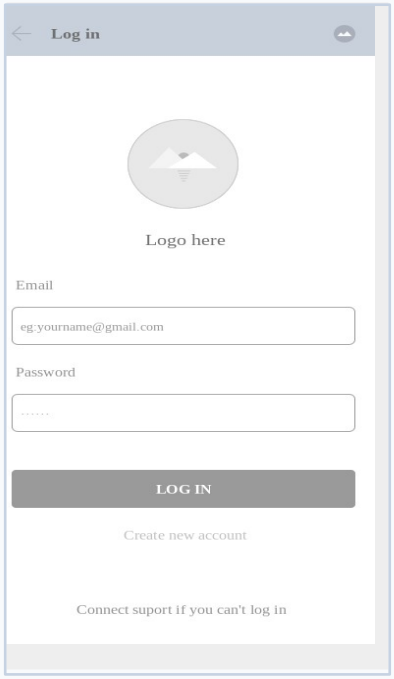
Before usability study



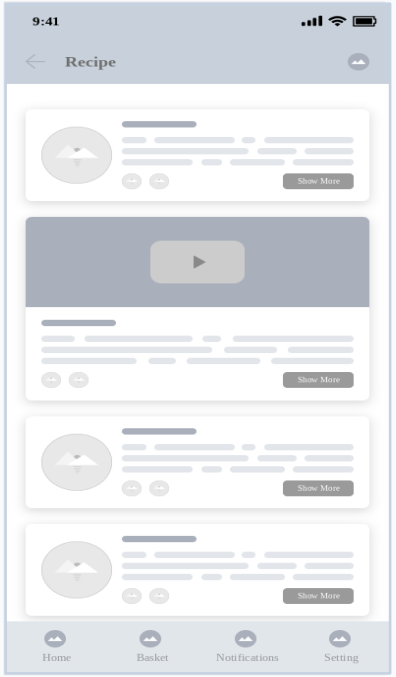
After usability study



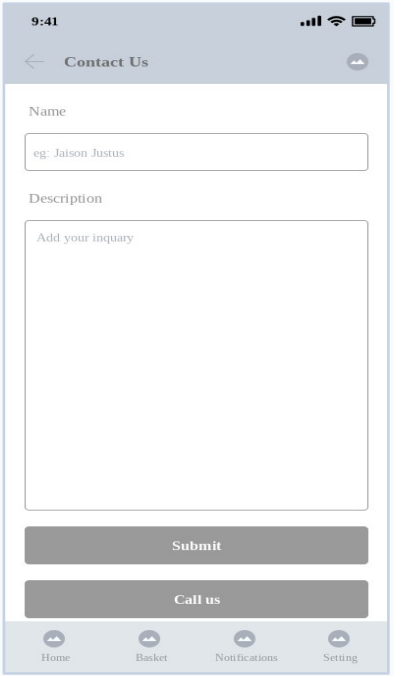
Mockups



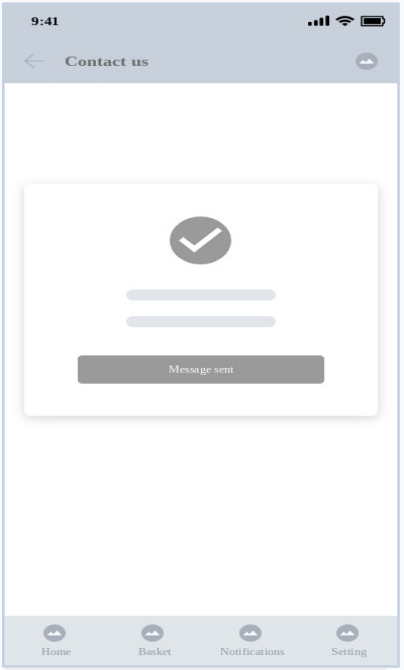
Log in



Recipe

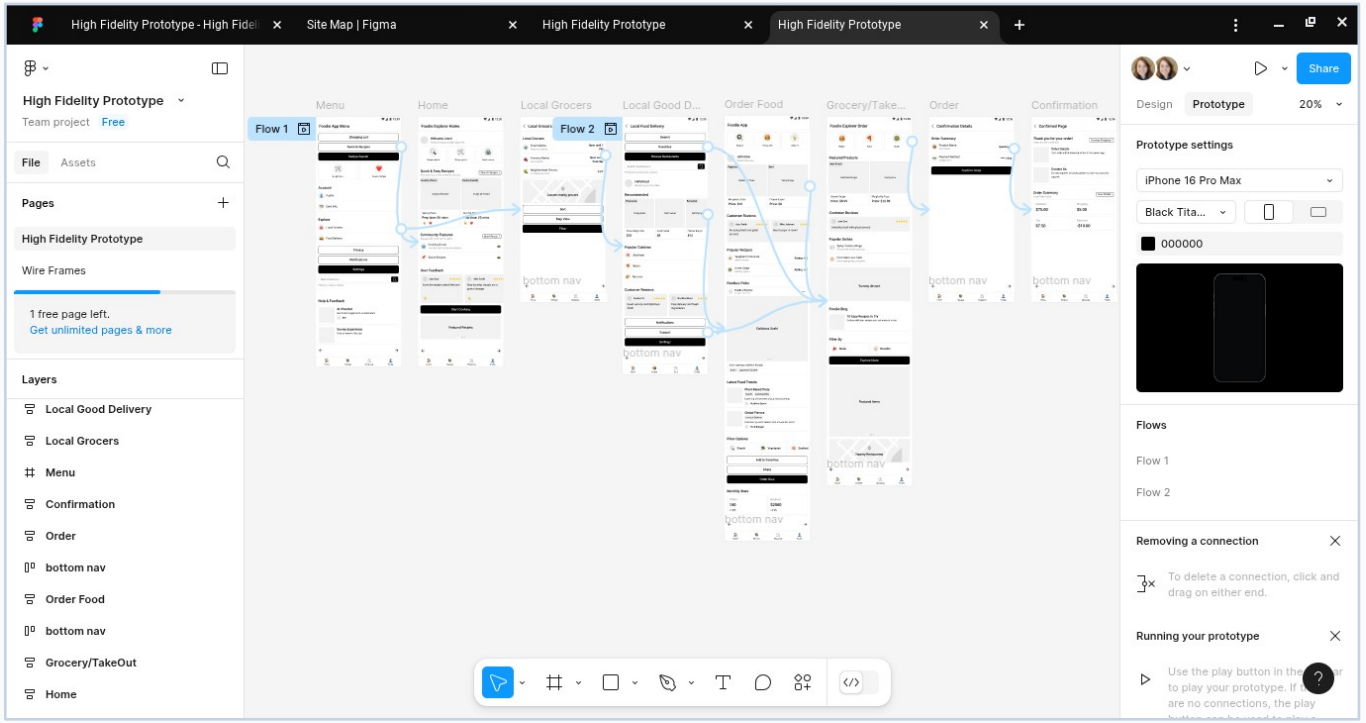


Contact Us



Message sent

High-fidelity prototype



Accessibility considerations

1

High-Contrast Mode & Readable Fonts

To improve readability for users with visual impairments, the app includes a high-contrast mode and legible font choices, ensuring text remains clear and accessible.

2

Voice Search & Screen Reader Compatibility

The app supports voice search functionality and is optimized for screen readers, allowing users with motor or visual impairments to navigate and interact with ease.

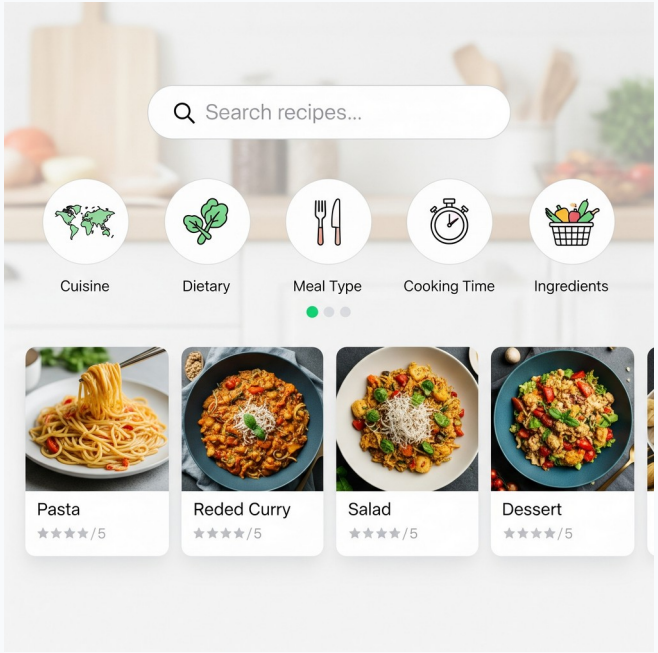
3

Clear Navigation & Large Tap Targets

The design incorporates intuitive navigation with large, well-spaced buttons to accommodate users with limited dexterity, reducing the risk of misclicks and enhancing overall usability.

Key Design Decisions

- Focus on simplified path from recipe to order.
- Implemented an intuitive, filtered recipe search.
- Streamlined the checkout process to save user time.
- Integrated auto-generated shopping lists for efficiency.



04

Going forward

- Takeaways
- Next steps

Takeaways

Impact:

The redesigned Foodie Explorer app streamlined grocery shopping and recipe discovery, making it easier for users to plan and prepare meals efficiently. One study participant noted, "The app is so intuitive and saves me so much time, now I can quickly find recipes and order groceries without stress!"

What I learned:

This project reinforced the importance of user-centered design and iterative improvements based on real feedback. It also highlighted how small usability changes and accessibility features can significantly enhance the user experience.

Next steps

1

Conduct Further Usability Testing

Gathering more user feedback will help refine features, ensuring a seamless and intuitive experience.

2

Enhance Personalization

Recommendations based on past orders and dietary preferences will improve engagement.

3

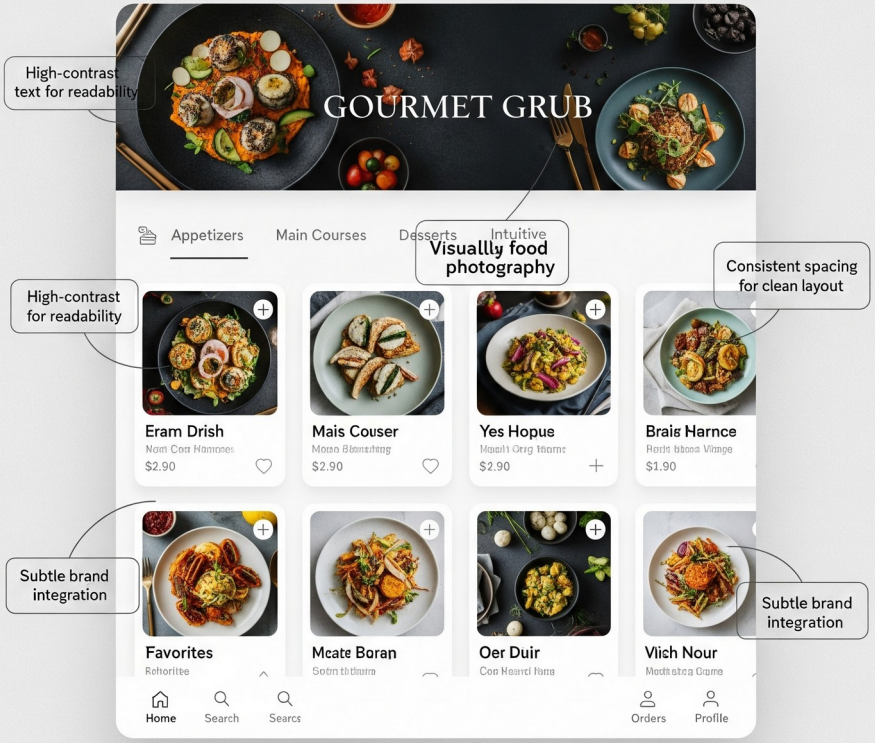
Expand Accessibility Features

Adding multilingual support and more assistive technologies will make the app even more inclusive for a diverse user base.

Measuring Success: KPIs

- Measure user engagement with personalized suggestions.
- Track the time saved during the streamlined checkout process.
- Monitor the completion rate for grocery list orders.
- Evaluate the overall user satisfaction and efficiency.





Future Design Hypotheses

- Expand personalized recommendations based on past orders and dietary preferences.
- Further usability tests will refine existing key features.
- Integrate new assistive technologies for better inclusion.
- Focus on developing multilingual support for a global audience.

Let’s connect!

Next I would test the redesigned flows with another round of users, then build out personalization and accessibility from what I learn. The goal stays the same: a calmer, faster path from finding a recipe to getting groceries.

Feel free to reach out to me to discuss this project or explore more of my work.

https://www.linkedin.com/in/millrjess for more case studies.

© 2026 Jessica A. Miller